Mahatma Gandhi University, Kottayam-

Second Semester MGU-UGP – BSW (Honours) Regular Examination March 2025

Discipline Specific Core Course -- MG2DSCSWK100 - Philosophical Foundations Of Social Work

- QP Code: 25900189

Part A Short Answer Questions Answer any five questions / each question carries 2 marks

1. Identify one example of fidelity in practice An example of fidelity in practice is a social worker keeping a promise to follow up with a client within a specific timeframe, demonstrating trustworthiness and commitment.	[U] / CO1] 2 marks
2. List out any two core values of social work Integrity Social Justice	[K] / [CO2] 1 marks 1 marks
3. Explain the value of dignity and self-determination in brief. The value of **dignity and self-determination** refers to respecting each individual's inherent worth and allowing them to make their own choices. Social workers empower clients to take control of their lives and support their autonomy in decision-making.	[U] /[CO2] 2 marks
4. List two ways to maintain professionalism in relationships. Establish and maintain **clear boundaries** with clients. Maintain **respectful and ethical communication** at all times.	[K] / [CO2] 1 marks 1 marks
5. Identify one way equity can be ensured in service delivery. Providing **culturally competent services** that are tailored to the diverse needs of clients ensures equity by recognizing and addressing individual differences.	[U] / [CO3] 2 marks
6. Define confidentiality and informed consent in the context of social work practice ➢ **Confidentiality** is the ethical duty of social workers to protect clients' private information and only share it when legally required or with the client's permission. ➢ **Informed consent** means that clients are given all necessary information about services, risks, and rights in a clear and understandable manner, enabling them to voluntarily agree to participate.	[K] / [CO4] 1marks 1marks
7. Discuss the meaning of social justice **Social justice** in social work means advocating for equal rights, opportunities, and treatment for all individuals, particularly marginalized and disadvantaged groups. It involves challenging injustices and working to remove barriers to resources and well-being.	[U] / [CO4 2 marks

Part B Short Essay Answer any 4 questions Each question carries 5 marks

8. Illustrate how a social worker should respond to a client's illegal behavior **A social worker should respond** a) nonjudgmentally and with professionalism, b) assessing the situation to determine the client's needs, risks, and legal obligations. **For example,** if a client admits to drug use, the social worker might discuss harm reduction strategies, refer them to treatment services, and explain any legal limitations to confidentiality, such as mandatory reporting.	[A] / [CO2 2.5 marks 2.5 marks
9. Describe how personal values can help social workers manage stress ethically. a) Personal values such as **resilience, empathy, and integrity** b) It guide ethical decision-making and help social workers remain grounded during challenging situations. c) These values encourage self-reflection, professional boundaries, and stress-reducing practices like supervision and self-care, ensuring ethical behavior even under pressure.	[U] /[CO4] 1 marks 1marks 2 marks
10. Apply the Evidence-Based model in addressing gender-based violence. Using the evidence-based model, a social worker would:	[A] / CO4]

• **Ask**: Identify the specific issue (e.g., trauma in survivors of gender-based violence). • **Acquire**: Search for research-supported interventions (e.g., trauma-informed care, CBT). • **Appraise**: Evaluate the quality and relevance of the evidence. • **Apply**: Tailor the intervention to the client's cultural and individual context. • **Assess**: Monitor outcomes and adjust as needed. This model ensures interventions are both effective and client-centered.	0.5 marks 0.5 marks 1 marks 1marks 1 marks
11. Describe how the value of dignity and worth of the person influences ethical decisions. ➢ Value of Dignity reminds social workers to treat clients with respect, regardless of their circumstances. ➢ Ethical decisions are made with the client's best interest in mind, avoiding harm, promoting autonomy, and recognizing each person's right to be heard and to make their own choices.	[U] / [CO5 5 marks
12. Discuss situations where maintaining confidentiality empowers clients during the decision-making process. ➢ When clients trust that their information is private, such as in cases of domestic violence or HIV status, they are more likely to share openly. ➢ This allows them to explore their options fully and make informed decisions without fear of stigma, judgment, or retaliation.	[U] / CO4] 5 marks
13. Explain how empathy enhances the effectiveness of a social worker. **Empathy allows social workers to** • truly understand clients' feelings and perspectives, building trust and rapport. • This improves communication, strengthens the client-worker relationship, • It also fosters a safe space for change and growth.	[U] / CO2] 5 marks
14. Illustrate the use of empathy across all three levels of social work practice. • **Micro (individual)**: A social worker listens actively to a client's trauma story without judgment, validating their feelings. • **Mezzo (group/family)**: Facilitating a support group for survivors, the worker uses empathetic communication to create a safe and trusting environment. • **Macro (community/policy)**: Advocating for housing rights, the worker uses empathy to understand community struggles and shape policies that reflect their lived experiences.	[A] / CO2] 5 marks

Part C Essay Answer any 2 questions Each question carries 10 marks

15. Critically examine the core philosophical foundations and values of social work. How do these influence ethical practice in real-world settings? i) Social work is rooted in **human rights, social justice, dignity, and the worth of every individual**. Philosophically, it draws on principles from **deontology (duty-based ethics), utilitarianism (maximizing well-being), and virtue ethics (character and moral integrity)**. These values promote client-centered care, advocacy for the oppressed, and professional integrity. ii) In real-world settings, these principles guide decisions on issues such as resource allocation, advocacy, confidentiality, and client autonomy. For example, a social worker may have to balance institutional rules with the ethical obligation to advocate for a homeless client's right to housing, even if that means challenging the status quo. These foundations ensure ethical consistency while addressing complex, real-life challenges.	[E] / [CO6 5 marks 5 marks
16. Assess the implications of unresolved ethical dilemmas on professional social work practice. i) Unresolved ethical dilemmas can lead to **a) moral distress**, b) burnout, and c) impaired decision-making. ii) Example: if a social worker is caught between reporting a teen's criminal activity and preserving therapeutic trust, failure to resolve this conflict may affect their relationship with the client, their credibility with stakeholders, or even result in legal consequences.	A] / [CO3] 2 marks 3 marks

iii) Over time, unresolved dilemmas can erode professional standards, damage client trust, and reduce the quality of service. iv) They may also expose the agency to liability or compromise the worker's professional standing. Ethical supervision and consultation are vital to help resolve such dilemmas effectively.	3 marks 2marks
17. Evaluate the importance of maintaining competence for delivering effective and responsible social services i. Competence is a **core ethical obligation** and critical to providing high-quality, evidence-informed services. Social work constantly evolves with new laws, research, and client needs. Without ongoing education and training, a social worker risks using outdated methods, misinterpreting cultural contexts, or violating legal and ethical standards. ii. a) Maintaining competence ensures accountability, promotes client trust, and aligns practice with the profession's ethical code. b) It also enables innovation in interventions and enhances interprofessional collaboration, especially in fields like mental health, child protection, or disability services.	[E] / [CO4] 4 marks 6marks
18. Evaluate the ethical strengths and challenges of applying philosophical values in community practice • Philosophical values like **social justice** and **community empowerment** inspire inclusive practices, participatory decision-making, and advocacy for marginalized groups. • They provide a **moral compass** that helps social workers navigate competing interests and advocate for systemic change. **Challenges:** • Real-world constraints, such as political agendas, funding limitations, or community resistance, may conflict with these ideals. • Balancing **individual rights** with **community needs** can create ethical tensions (e.g., advocating for needle exchange programs that face public opposition). Ultimately, applying philosophical values in community work requires critical reflection, ethical dialogue, and strategic advocacy to remain effective and accountable.	[E] / [CO4] 5 marks 5 marks